

Session 11: Genesis 1 Imagery in Jeremiah 4

Key Takeaways

- The words used to describe the pre-creation state in Genesis—*tohu va-vohu*—mean “wild and waste” (e.g., Jer. 4:23).
- Wild and waste, darkness, and the deep waters are images for the pre-creation state of non-order.
- Jeremiah is activating day one of Genesis, but reversing it. He’s talking about the ruin of their city and calling it an undoing of creation—a lack of order and of human flourishing.
- Using these Genesis 1 images heightens the sense of disaster. God is allowing humans to de-create Jerusalem.

Exploring Wild and Waste in Jeremiah 4

Let’s focus on the Genesis 1 imagery in Jeremiah 4, specifically the concept of wild and waste. Consider how Jeremiah 4 helps us to better understand wild and waste in Genesis 1.



This session expands on the notes found in Session 10

Reflection Question

How is Jeremiah 4 using ideas and words from Genesis 1? Does the use of *tohu va-vohu* (wild and waste) in particular help us understand what this phrase means in Genesis 1?